

## Have you ever had sex with a prostitute from a different country?

YES **15**      NO **52**      But I would like to **32**

Male 14 Female 26      Male 52 Female 55      Male 34 Female 19

*Female respondents of the total of 633 who say they have had sex with a prostitute. Rest don't know, can't say. All figures in per cent*

**Fourteen per cent of the men who have had sex with a prostitute, say they have slept with a foreign prostitute at least once.**

metrosexual men have decreased libidos and can only afford to watch, not do? Not quite. For bigger pleasures await them. In Mumbai, for example, there is a plethora of foreign prostitutes, and 27 per cent of the city has encountered them. Immune from laws, this also becomes a "safer way" for some to have sex. The foreigners are aware of AIDS and sexually transmitted diseases, and they take precautions to make it a healthy, wholesome experience, read, a condom, which remains an unnecessary safeguard for many people.

India's prostitution industry anyway is doing roaring business, with a reported annual turnover of Rs 2,000 crore. One of the biggest revelations is, it is men now who have a fair share of the pie. In the metros, more and more women engage male prostitutes, or approve of it—17 per cent in Mumbai, 15 per cent in Delhi and 13 per cent in Kolkata. Bangalore is where foreign male prostitutes (62 per cent of women who engaged gigolos prefer exotic varieties) seem to be having a great time, and why not, considering 40 per cent of India's expat population lives here, and some

of the women on assignments can get very lonely.

But while the country's men and women indulge in paid sex, it remains a grey area legally. ITPA criminalises neither sex work nor sex workers, but makes solicitation in a "public place" illegal. India's sex workers' unions have long rallied against the Act, because it leads to harassment by the police. The proposed amendment to the Act in 2005, which criminalised the customer, and could earn him a jail term of three years, and not the sex worker, was even more violently opposed. But a simplistic argument could be that if paid sex is available in so many forms, why not this one? In any case, laws don't seem to put a clamp on prostitution, which finds a new cloak to sell itself. If physical solicitation puts you behind bars, there's always Internet soliciting.

But if paying for sex is not an option, consider others. Pick up the phone or buy that magazine in a jacket. Or simply visit the local video parlour. If you have the money, you have the power.

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